



Microinfluencer campaigns such as this one by Cadbury are cost effective and scalable

to their target audience, and will follow them everywhere. For us outsiders looking in, it's a lot easier to spot a promising social network, or a change in type of content or user behaviour, because we can follow the advertisers, who pay hundreds of people to keep them updated with everything that their target audience is doing. While this may be useless for seeing trends before they happen, it's great to spot smaller trends that are happening, which may or may not boom in the near future.

What we at Digit don't see happening is the Wikipedia of Social Media coming in to destroy the business model. The Wikipedia model is awesome for sharing of information, but social media is so much more than that. [WT:Social](#)<sup>3</sup>, which was Wikipedia founder Jimmy Wales' brainchild, has some very loyal followers, but it's not really taking the social media world by storm. Why? Because it's serious about what it does, and it's not really built for fun and showing off. It's built to share information, cut out disinformation, stop frivolous time-wasting, and be useful... which, given all the other social media behemoths out there, seems to be the exact opposite of what the masses want. Just spend an hour on Twitter, Facebook and TikTok each, and you will realise that all you got was either high bp, or some useless laughs at someone else's expense, but not too much in terms of useful knowledge. Then again, the argument for the flip side is that who goes on social media to learn anything? You go to college to do that, or train at work, etc. The whole point of social media (for most people) is to relax and have fun.

## SHOW ME THE MONEY!

You can find out how old I am just by dating that movie reference... The positive aspect of advertisers is that they bring money. As many influencers around the world have realised, advertisers are a very, very good thing if you're popular. There are people making millions doing all the stuff they would do normally anyway, and just throwing in some sponsored products. If there's one thing advertisers love, it is advertisements that are not marked as advertising. Platforms absolutely hate that, because they feel like they

deserve a share of the revenue, and users should hate it, because they are being sold something without even knowing it. While the influencer space might be worth billions abroad, in India it's estimated to be about a 100 million dollar market. That's a 725 crore INR market, which is not a small amount, is it? And given that it's expected to grow at an exponential rate, it's no wonder that the government is looking to draw up laws to regulate it. If nothing else, what's needed is that some sort of tag be applied to mark the content as sponsored, or as an ad. Just as Digit and other publishers are legally and morally responsible to inform you when some sponsored content we put online is paid for by advertisers, influencers too should inform their followers that they're accepting money, right?

In terms of Gen C, while they will get online a lot sooner than before, with some estimates ranging from as young as seven or eight years old, it will

be when they're in their teens that they will start looking towards becoming influencers. That's essentially around the year 2035, which seems like a very long way off for now. We have no clue what services or methods they will use to become famous and gather followers, but we're pretty sure it will happen. Online society is no different from real human lives, and we all have our local heroes and popular kids who everyone wants to be. These days there are already influencers earning millions of dollars a year, and that number is only set to rise, and the age of the kids earning that is set to gradually come down.



Coca Cola effectively uses all kinds of influencers from giga to nano

We don't even know what 2035 will hold in store for us in terms of employment or jobs. It's actually possible that being a social media whiz will not be a nice to have feature like today, but a must have, akin to a degree. While top jobs are already based on a circle of influence in the business world, this might well trickle down to every job there is. And with some of the technologies that we already have, your market worth might be dictated purely by how many people you can get as followers on whatever is the social media giant of the time. Will the beggars of the future be begging for likes and follows instead of cash? What a dystopian world that would be for most! 